

Can “bad” stressors spark “good” behaviors in frontline employees? Incorporating motivation and emotion

Can “bad”
stressors spark
“good”
behaviors?

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Abstract

Purpose – This study aims to investigate the antecedents of frontline employees’ boundary-spanning behaviors in the hospitality industry. Anchored in transactional stress theory, affective events theory and motivation theories, a conceptual model was built to explore the impacts of hindrance stressors on boundary-spanning behavior.

Design/methodology/approach – Data were collected from frontline employees in the hospitality industry in the USA. Confirmatory factor analysis and structural equation modeling were used.

Findings – The findings revealed that despite hindrance stressors’ negative indirect impact on frontline employees’ boundary-spanning behaviors, intrinsic motivation worked effectively to reduce hindrance stress and influence subsequent emotions leading to boundary-spanning behaviors.

Practical implications – This study provides substantial and detailed strategies for hospitality practitioners who are pressed to alleviate the hindrance stressors from which frontline employees frequently suffer, foster employees’ positive emotions and ease negative emotions while promoting boundary-spanning behaviors. Cultivation of employees’ intrinsic motivation and emotional management is encouraged, as is effective organizational structure and management intervention. All of these are deemed helpful in buffering employees’ work-related stress while motivating them to go above and beyond their nominal duties.

Originality/value – Very few studies have examined how “bad” hindrance stressors affect boundary-spanning behaviors. Rather than suggesting that hindrance stressors are relevant only to counterproductive behaviors, this study extends both the stress and boundary-spanning literature by uncovering the impact of hindrance stressors on frontline employees’ boundary-spanning behaviors while accounting for the roles of workers’ motivation and emotion.

Keywords Boundary-spanning behavior, Intrinsic motivation, Emotion, Frontline employees, Hindrance stressor

Paper type Research paper



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1. Introduction

The success of hospitality businesses is contingent on the competence of frontline employees in delivering quality service to guests. Questions of how to promote “going above and beyond” among these employees have been of concern to managers and academics alike (He *et al.*, 2019; Kim *et al.*, 2018). Although different types of hospitality businesses may have their own performance metrics, frontline employees in this sector generally act “as boundary spanners of both the company’s and customer’s interest” (Kim *et al.*, 2009, p. 612). Frontline employees as boundary spanners link external environments to internal operations, representing organizations to outsiders as ambassadors (Choi *et al.*, 2014) while advocating and helping improve the firm’s image via feedback (Yoo *et al.*, 2014). Boundary-spanning behavior not only provides quality service and settles customers’ complaints effectively, but also transmits information about customers’ requirements, complaints, and expectations to the company in question (Karatepe, 2012). That being said, service excellence in the hospitality industry can be challenging (Kang and Jang, 2019; Yu *et al.*, 2014), as frontline staff are constantly involved in direct interaction with various influencing parties (e.g. internal supervisors, co-workers and external customers) who may possess conflicting expectations (Coelho *et al.*, 2011; Kim *et al.*, 2009). The incongruence or fuzzy boundary between organizational in-role prescription and customer-oriented service requirement may lead to hindrance stressors, defined as work demands or circumstances that impede personal development or otherwise interfere with an individual’s achievement goals (Cavanaugh *et al.*, 2000). Hindrance stressors may involve a sense of role conflict and role ambiguity (Crawford *et al.*, 2010; Kim *et al.*, 2009), as hospitality frontline employees oftentimes face not only conflicting requests from different parties but also unclear and ambiguous expectations, all while performing as boundary spanners. Moreover, unlike non-service industries, the hospitality industry is characterized by delivery of an experience that extends beyond the provision of tangible goods. In addition, unlike 9–5 weekday jobs, hospitality positions involve irregular and long hours and work overload. Hospitality businesses depend on providing high-level, in-person customer service and handling multiple responsibilities simultaneously (Tsaur and Tang, 2012; Zeithaml *et al.*, 2017). As a result, hospitality frontline employees may experience more emotional exhaustion or burnout, which may harm the service experience and/or increase the likelihood of turnover (Yousaf *et al.*, 2020). Instead of going above and beyond, many frontline employees have reduced themselves to role-specific behaviors (Bettencourt and Brown, 2003).

While understanding and managing work-related role stress is a pressing concern in the hospitality industry (Min *et al.*, 2015; Olugbade and Karatepe, 2019), whether and how hindrance stressors influence hospitality frontline employees’ extra-role behaviors warrant more nuanced understanding. Existing organizational behavior studies regarding role stressors and their influence on job outcomes (Abbas and Raja, 2019; Hosie *et al.*, 2019; Lu *et al.*, 2016; Naseer *et al.*, 2020; Stamper and Johlke, 2003) have tended to endorse challenge stressors as the “good” stressors, exerting an impact on frontline employees’ job consequences, while neglecting the possibility that under influence of the “bad” hindrance stressors, desirable behaviors may still be triggered in certain contexts. Despite the conclusion drawn by general business literature (Crawford *et al.*, 2010), and hospitality research in particular (Babakus *et al.*, 2017; Geng *et al.*, 2014; Hu *et al.*, 2017), recent studies have hinted at the need to think beyond the commonly perceived detrimental effects of hindrance stressors on work outcomes (Kang and Jang, 2019; Karatepe *et al.*, 2018; Min *et al.*, 2015). Consequently, this study aims to explore factors that could buffer the effects of hindrance stressors on boundary spanners from motivational and emotional perspectives. Particularly, whether and how

intrinsic motivation, a tendency to participate in an activity not for extrinsic rewards (Deci, 1975), buffers the effect of hindrance stressors on high-contact employees' boundary-spanning behaviors (Bettencourt and Brown, 2003) remains unanswered in a hospitality context.

This study examines boundary-spanning behaviors from the perspective of hindrance stressors, accounting for hospitality frontline employees' intrinsic motivation and emotions. The specific objectives of this study are as follows:

- to test how the two dimensions of hindrance stressors (role conflict and role ambiguity) influence frontline employees' boundary-spanning behaviors through their emotions (positive and negative); and
- to examine the role of frontline employees' intrinsic motivation in reducing hindrance stressors and influencing their emotions and behaviors.

This research is of both theoretical and practical significance. Theoretically, it represents a pioneering effort to investigate the motivational and emotional impacts of hindrance stressors on frontline employees' boundary-spanning behaviors. Managerially, it arms practitioners in the hospitality industry with new knowledge about how to manage the negative effects of hindrance stressors by inspiring employees to “above and beyond” in the job performance.

2. Literature review and hypotheses development

This study is anchored in three theoretical streams: transactional stress theory, affective events theory and the construct of intrinsic motivation from several motivational theoretical frameworks. In line with transactional stress theory (Lazarus and Folkman, 1984), when external requests exceed an employee's resources, he/she tends to experience psychological stress. Therefore, employees are likely to suffer psychological stress when their duties, jurisdiction, or scope of authority fail to meet external requirements – hence our proposition that emotions respond to hindrance stressors. Moreover, drawing on affective events theory (Weiss and Cropanzano, 1996), feelings generated by workplace events influence employees' subsequent behaviors and performance (Fisher, 2000). Thus, emotions provide the basis for predicting individual engagement and organizational behaviors (Eatough *et al.*, 2011; Spector and Fox, 2002). This study also incorporates intrinsic motivation to gauge the influence of personal resources on employees' performance (Karatepe and Karadas, 2015). According to motivation theories, including achievement goal theory (Ames, 1992) and self-determination theory (Deci, 1975), individuals' motivations and performance-related behaviors stem from their principal goal orientations and inherent growth tendencies. Driven by certain goals or needs, an individual concentrates on learning, adjusting and engagement (Ames, 1992). Thus, it is possible that internally motivated high-contact employees buffer the impact of hindrance stressors while still performing “above and beyond” in hospitality organizations. Integrating these three theoretical perspectives, and taking into account the unique characteristics of the hospitality industry, this study builds and tests the relationships between hindrance stressors and frontline employees' boundary-spanning behaviors.

2.1 Boundary-spanning behaviors

Building on organizational citizenship behavior (Bettencourt *et al.*, 2001), boundary-spanning theory draws a line of demarcation between an organization and its external environment and recognizes the social and economic transactions taking place across the

said demarcation. Distinct from organizational citizenship behavior, boundary-spanning takes form as “job-related interactions with a person who is considered part of the environment” and is embodied by someone who is “not a member of the organization” (Robertson, 1995, p. 75). Boundary-spanning behaviors pinpoint the unique nature of boundary crossing in organizational contexts. This subjects boundary spanners to the expectations not only of the parent system but also of an interactive system beyond immediate purview (Wall and Adams, 1974). In hospitality firms, frontline employees are considered typical boundary-spanners who help promote service delivery through interpersonal relationships (Huang *et al.*, 2016), monitoring of customer preferences and demands (Peng and Heath, 1996) and introduction of innovations to products and services (Manev and Stevenson, 2001). Because of the highly personal and experiential nature of hospitality experiences, responses to customers’ requests heavily rely on ability of frontline employees to span boundaries in every service encounter.

Tying the organization in question with external stakeholders (Barnes *et al.*, 2015; Korschun, 2015), boundary-spanning behaviors are manifested across three dimensions: external representation, internal influence and service delivery behavior (Bettencourt and Brown, 2003). External representation denotes employees’ vocal promotion and advocacy of an organization’s products and service to outsiders (Bowen and Schneider, 1985). Internal influence occurs when employees take initiatives to communicate with an organization and/or colleagues to improve service delivery (Zeithaml *et al.*, 1988). Service delivery refers to providing service to customers with a responsiveness, courtesy and flexibility (Parasuraman *et al.*, 1988).

As boundary spanners who serve both a firm’s and its customers’ interests, hospitality frontline employees are often expected to perform in a uniquely stressful environment, which involves not only dealing with intensive workloads and non-routine work schedules (Coelho *et al.*, 2011; Hu *et al.*, 2017) but also addressing conflicting demands from a variety of stakeholders per sometimes-vague instructions (Kim *et al.*, 2009). Consequently, studying hospitality employees’ boundary-spanning behavior is crucial when considering the many role stressors of their working conditions. Rigorous examination of how said conditions promote boundary-spanning behaviors is still nascent in the hospitality literature, despite a few studies in tourism and hospitality contexts focusing on boundary spanners (Hu *et al.*, 2017; Jung and Yoon, 2020; Ying and Norman, 2017). Yet, to the best of the authors’ knowledge, literature exploring the influence of hindrance stressors on boundary-spanning behaviors remains scarce.

2.2 Hindrance stressors

Stress is a series of physical and psychological responses to adverse yet unavoidable environments or influences (Selye, 1964, 1956). Experiencing stress can be either pleasant or unpleasant depending on the demand stimulus (Le Fevre *et al.*, 2003). Selye’s (1956) concept of eustress or “good stress,” for example, sees moderate amounts of pressure, anxiety or fear as leading to improved performance at work (Certo, 2003; Le Fevre *et al.*, 2003). Stress, whether “good” or “bad” (if not a combination of the two), is one’s response to stressors (Le Fevre *et al.*, 2003). Two major stressors often studied in work environments are challenges and hindrances (Cavanaugh *et al.*, 2000). Challenge stressors, related to eustress, may serve as a source of motivation and result in positive work outcomes, while hindrance stressors represent energy-depleting job demands that lead to reduced work engagement (Schaufeli and Bakker, 2004). Thus, hindrance stressors are barriers to individual growth and work productivity.

Role conflict and role ambiguity are two major hindrance stressors for frontline employees (Rodell and Judge, 2009). Role conflict arises from conflicting requests of different

parties (e.g. managers, supervisors, co-workers and customers) (Malhotra and Ackfeldt, 2016), leading to uncertainty among employees trying to accommodate those conflicting requests (Hu *et al.*, 2017). Role ambiguity denotes a lack of sufficient information to support employees in fulfilling their responsibilities (Malhotra and Ackfeldt, 2016), which confuses employees about their duties and associated expectations (Hu *et al.*, 2017). Both types of work-related stress are salient to the hospitality industry, where frontline employees are constantly exposed to stressors from customers and supervisors (Tepeci and Bartlett, 2002) and are expected to accommodate conflicting demands under ambiguous expectations. Increasing standards in the hospitality industry require better service experiences, promptness of response and personalized deliveries, among other soft amenities (Yu *et al.*, 2014), all of which heighten the work-related stress faced by hospitality frontline employees.

Following the transactional stress model (Lazarus and Folkman, 1984), whenever frontline employees face role conflict or ambiguity, they tend to experience changes in the psychological outcomes of job satisfaction, loyalty, positive well-being and engagement (Widmer *et al.*, 2012; Yao *et al.*, 2015). The same is true of hospitality (Choi and Kim, 2012; Ghiselli *et al.*, 2001; Kurucz *et al.*, 2008). Further evidence from a range of other industries has implied that role conflict and ambiguity inhibit job satisfaction (Karatepe and Sokmen, 2006; Walsh, 2011), positive well-being (Widmer *et al.*, 2012) and employee engagement (Min *et al.*, 2015). Such role stressors reduce positive emotions (Walsh, 2011; Widmer *et al.*, 2012) supposed to foster prosocial performance and cooperative behaviors (Carlson *et al.*, 1988). Based on the preceding review, this study proposes the following hypotheses:

H1. Role conflict negatively influences positive emotions.

H2. Role ambiguity negatively influences positive emotions.

In addition to decreasing positive work emotions, hindrance stressors produce negative emotions (Chen *et al.*, 2019; Hu *et al.*, 2017). In the hospitality industry, known for occupational stress (Huertas-Valdivia *et al.*, 2018), frontline employees are more likely to experience burnout or emotional exhaustion (Chen *et al.*, 2019; Han *et al.*, 2016; Podsakoff *et al.*, 2007). Thus, this study proposes the following hypotheses:

H3. Role ambiguity positively influences negative emotions.

H4. Role conflict positively influences negative emotions.

Although studies have tested role conflict and role ambiguity as undesirable antecedents to employee attitudes (Chen *et al.*, 2019; Eatough *et al.*, 2011; Kim *et al.*, 2009), the relationship between the two remains inconclusive. While Low *et al.* (2001) argued that increased levels of role ambiguity led to increased levels of role conflict, role conflict has been shown to positively influence role ambiguity in hospitals (Coelho *et al.*, 2011) and sports teams (Petersen, 1971). In light of the inconclusive data, this study considers the unique organizational context of the hospitality industry, where frontline employees must navigate multiple and conflicting requests during interpersonal interactions, making it difficult to prioritize expectations (Babin and Boles, 1996). This may, in turn, imply a more serious impact on employees' job satisfaction and organizational outcomes (Kim *et al.*, 2009). Therefore, to further explore the relationship between role conflict and role ambiguity, this study proposes the following hypothesis:

H5. Role conflict positively influences role ambiguity.

2.3 Emotions

Emotions refer to a positive or negative feeling derived from a particular mode of activity, leading to bodily, cognitive and behavioral changes (Schacter *et al.*, 2011). The current study adopts an “emotions as conceptual constructions” approach (Barrett, 2006) instead of an “emotions as natural kinds” approach (Izard, 2007). According to the former conceptualization, emotions are not “biologically given” but are “conceptual constructions that emerge from our categorisation of a more basic psychological process” (Fox, 2018, p. 4). As conceptual constructions that inform rational discussion and decision-making, emotional states can manifest through such dimensions as anger, contempt, distress, enjoyment, interest and surprise (Izard, 2007).

In hospitality settings, frontline employees’ emotional states play an important role in optimizing interactions with customers, thus ensuring quality service delivery (Li *et al.*, 2018). Researchers have, therefore, encouraged frontline employees to display positive emotions (Shani *et al.*, 2014). In the context of organizational behavior, Grobelna (2019) argued that positive emotions inspired higher levels of engagement among hospitality employees. Fredrickson (2001) reported that positive emotions can broaden the array of workplace behaviors, promoting more discretionary responsibilities. Furthermore, job satisfaction was found to promote boundary-spanning behaviors in many sectors (Bettencourt *et al.*, 2005; Huertas-Valdivia *et al.*, 2018). Thus, to further explore the impact of positive emotions on boundary-spanning behaviors, this study proposes the following hypothesis:

H6. Positive emotions positively influence boundary-spanning behaviors.

Positive emotions are not the only reactions experienced in a working environment. In a hospitality context, constantly changing working scenarios and diverse customer needs bring about a unique set of work-related stressors, leading to frontline employees’ burnout and emotional exhaustion (Chen *et al.*, 2019; Han *et al.*, 2016). Such psychological consequences negatively affect boundary-spanners’ job performance in service settings (Ambrose *et al.*, 2014). Instead of going above and beyond, many frontline employees may reduce and limit themselves to role-specific behaviors (Bettencourt and Brown, 2003) or even exhibit deviant behavior (Hu *et al.*, 2017). Accordingly, this study proposes the following hypothesis:

H7. Negative emotions negatively influence boundary-spanning behaviors.

2.4 Intrinsic motivation

Motivation, as an important determinant of individual behavior (Deci and Ryan, 2000), has drawn much attention in organizational behavior studies (Pinder, 2014). Intrinsic motivation sees an individual’s behavior as arising solely from self-interest or self-fulfillment (Hennessey and Amabile, 1988). In line with self-determination theory (Deci, 1975), which posits that individuals’ motivations and performance-related behaviors stem from their goal orientations and inherent growth tendencies, intrinsic motivation is essential for fostering individual cognition, which helps one seek innovation and challenges, as well as face and overcome difficulties (Ryan and Deci, 2000). Employees with high intrinsic motivation tend to focus on a sense of achievement (Daskin and Surucu, 2016), contributing to employees’ dedication (Katz, 2005) and willing efforts in organizations (Tang and Ibrahim, 1998). The best frontline employees in the hospitality industry are usually intrinsically motivated

(Brewer, 1994). They also consider hospitality service as a form of self-expression because it brings pleasure and welfare to guests (Poulston, 2015). Given the stressors faced by frontline employees in hospitality settings, understanding how motivated they are to deliver exceptional boundary-spanning experiences is particularly valuable (Grobela, 2015).

Intrinsic motivation significantly predicts hospitality employees' attitudes, psychological status and performance (Chen *et al.*, 2019; Jiang *et al.*, 2020; Karatepe, 2015). Intrinsically motivated employees in both general businesses (Auger and Woodman, 2016; Ganster *et al.*, 2011; Lin, 2011) and hospitality organizations (Daskin and Surucu, 2016; Karatepe, 2015; Lee and Kim, 2017; Schuckert *et al.*, 2018; Wang *et al.*, 2014) tend to be more adaptable to dynamic working environments and resilient to workplace stress, allowing them to better cope with demanding and confusing situations. Similar findings illustrated that hospitality employees with high levels of hope, customer orientation and proactive personality can self-regulate their stress levels (Kang and Jang, 2019; Karatepe *et al.*, 2018; Zhao and Guo, 2019). In line with existing knowledge, the current study proposes that intrinsic motivation helps minimize the role conflict and role ambiguity experienced by customer-contact employees. Hence, the following hypotheses are proposed:

H8. Intrinsic motivation reduces role conflict.

H9. Intrinsic motivation reduces role ambiguity.

Intrinsic motivation is associated with positive affect and passion (Shalley *et al.*, 2004). Intrinsically motivated employees driven by goal achievement show a strong willingness to engage (Gagné and Deci, 2005). Intrinsic motivation not only helps produce positive emotions among frontline employees in hospitality firms (Poulston, 2015) but also protects them against stress, fatigue and frustration (Chen *et al.*, 2019; Karatepe *et al.*, 2018). Therefore, this study proposes the following hypotheses:

H10. Intrinsic motivation enhances positive emotions.

H11. Intrinsic motivation reduces negative emotions.

A conceptual model for the study was constructed based on the preceding arguments, as depicted in Figure 1.

3. Methodology

3.1 Questionnaire design

This research used a quantitative method to assess the proposed model. Two screening questions were implemented at the beginning of the questionnaire: “Do you work in the

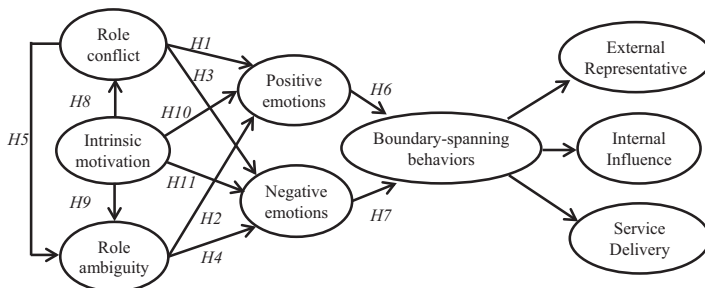


Figure 1.
Conceptual
framework

hospitality industry (hotels, restaurants, resorts) in the USA?” and “At work, do you directly interact with guests daily?” The respondents were required to rate their assessment of intrinsic motivation, role conflict, role ambiguity, positive emotions, negative emotions and boundary-spanning behaviors. They were also asked to provide job-related and demographic information. A seven-point Likert-type scale was used, with “1 = *strongly disagree*” and “7 = *strongly agree*.”

Multi-item indicators were adapted from previous studies to operationalize the major constructs. Intrinsic motivation was evaluated by a four-item scale from [Low *et al.* \(2001\)](#) (e.g. “When I do work well, it gives me a feeling of accomplishment”). Four items measuring role conflict and role ambiguity were adopted from [Stamper and Johlke \(2003\)](#) (e.g. “I receive assignments without adequate resources and materials to complete them”). The scales of emotional feelings were developed by [Jin \(2008\)](#) and empirically tested by [Zhao \(2012\)](#), with five items for positive emotions (e.g. “I always feel pleasant at work”) and four for negative emotions (e.g. “I always feel frustrated at work”). Finally, based on the conceptual definitions developed by [Bettencourt *et al.* \(2005\)](#), the boundary-spanning behavioral items were classified into three dimensions: evaluate external representation (four items), internal influence (four items) and service delivery (five items).

3.2 Data collection

An online version of the questionnaire powered by Qualtrics was prepared, using Amazon Mechanical Turk (MTurk) as the means of collecting data. MTurk served as an online pool with large and diverse workers completing the required tasks ([Paolacci and Chandler, 2014](#)) and proved useful for yielding reliable and viable samples ([Buhrmester *et al.*, 2011](#)).

Before proceeding to data collection, the questionnaire was approved by the Institutional Review Board (IRB), which ensured that all ethical guidelines were met within IRB standards. Meanwhile, respondents were informed that their participation was voluntary and that they could quit the survey at any time. The questionnaire did not collect any identifiable personal information.

Before the main study, a pilot test was executed, yielding 230 questionnaires through MTurk in December 2018. Of these, 187 complete questionnaires were considered eligible: a response rate of 81.3%. All dimensions showed good internal consistency, with Cronbach’s α value for all constructs scoring between 0.842 and 0.953, and a total scale of 0.809 ([Nunnally, 1978](#)). Meanwhile, factor analysis and Bartlett’s test were used to confirm the validity of the scales. The Kaiser–Meyer–Olkin value was 0.914 (sig. < 0.001), with 78.262% of total variance explained, showing that indicators matched well with the constructs ([Hair *et al.*, 2010](#)). The pilot study also revealed that one item in each construct of role conflict (“I receive incompatible requests from two or more people”) and role ambiguity (“I have clear, planned goals and objectives for my job”) did not load on the intended dimensions and were therefore removed from the final questionnaire.

The formal survey was carried out on January 17–20, 2019. A total of 680 questionnaires were distributed on the same platform. Participants of the pilot test were prevented from re-taking the survey. Respondents who completed the questionnaires were paid a small honorarium. The authors checked the participants’ IP addresses to confirm that all respondents were in the USA. To ensure that the participants maintained attention throughout the process, attention check questions that required a specific answer to a question (e.g. “Please choose ‘agree’ as your response to this statement”) were embedded in the questionnaire. After eliminating 123 incomplete and

unusable questionnaires, 557 responses were included for data analysis, representing a response rate of 81.9%. The average survey completion time of the eligible respondents ranged from 199 to 1,474 s. This large sample was sufficient to ensure a high level of statistical validity (McQuitty, 2004).

3.3 Data analysis

SPSS 25.0 and AMOS 25.0 were used to process the data. First, a descriptive analysis was conducted to provide baseline information on the study constructs. Next, confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was applied via AMOS 25.0 to verify the structural relationships among factors and constructs of the conceptual model. Next, the reliability and validity of scales were examined. In this study, both first- and second-order models were used to validate the structure of boundary-spanning behavior because of its three sub-dimensions. While the first-order model is used to assess the relationship between latent and observed variables (Bollen, 1989), the second-order model helps confirm the first-order latent variables and their higher latent factors, among which first-order factors are distinct and share significant variance (Jarvis *et al.*, 2003). Third, structural equation modeling was applied to assess the hypothesized paths, and common fit indices were used to evaluate the model fit (Anderson and Gerbing, 1988).

4. Findings

4.1 Sample profile

The data involved 298 males and 257 females. Slightly more than half of the respondents were between the ages of 25 and 34 (54.58%) and most had a white ethnic background (81.69%). Respondents with a two-year college education represented the largest proportion (41.47%).

The median annual income (before taxes) was \$30,000–\$39,999. Most of the respondents (81.50%) had worked in their current position for 3 years or less. Table 1 presents the descriptive statistics of the survey sample. Respondents represented a variety of job positions in the hospitality industry, such as waiter/waitress, bartender, front desk clerk, receptionist, concierge, bellman, housekeeper, cashier, coordinator, supervisor, director and duty/shift manager. Among others, the front office (i.e. front desk clerk, receptionist, concierge, bellman, etc.) constituted the largest share (36.40%), followed by the category of waiter/waitress, bartender and attendant (34.60%).

4.2 Measurement model

The CFA of 32 items, which included three sub-dimensions of boundary-spanning behaviors, along with intrinsic motivation, role conflict, role ambiguity, positive emotions and negative emotions, was conducted. The first-order model showed a reasonable fit ($\chi^2 = 1369.94$, $df = 436$, $\chi^2/df = 3.142$, goodness-of-fit index (GFI) = 0.859, adjusted goodness-of-fit index (AGFI) = 0.830, normalized fit index (NFI) = 0.898, incremental fit index (IFI) = 0.928, Tucker-Lewis index (TLI) = 0.918, comparative fit index (CFI) = 0.928, root mean square error of approximation (RMSEA) = 0.062). Although the values of GFI and AGFI were below 0.90, these values depend on the sample size; hence, 0.80–0.90 is considered an acceptable range (Byrne, 2001). Table 2 demonstrates that all constructs' standardized regression weights were higher than 0.5 with a significant level at $p < 0.001$, and that the t -values for each factor loading was above the critical score of 1.96 (Hair *et al.*, 2010). The lowest average variance extracted (AVE) score was 0.550, greater than 0.50, confirming adequate convergent validity of the scales (Fornell and Larcker, 1981). The composite reliability (CR) of the factors, ranging from 0.830 to 0.912 (intrinsic motivation: 0.912, role ambiguity: 0.870, role conflict: 0.850, positive emotions: 0.910, negative emotions: 0.884, external preventative: 0.830, internal influence: 0.847, and service delivery: 0.892), exceeded the benchmarking of 0.70, thus supporting the scales' internal consistency (Bagozzi and Yi, 1988).

Table 1.
Profile of
respondents

	Number	Total (N = 557) Proportion (%)
<i>Gender</i>		
Male	298	53.50
Female	257	46.14
Other	2	0.36
<i>Age (in years)</i>		
18–24	56	10.05
25–34	304	54.58
35–44	131	23.52
45–54	45	8.08
55–64	17	3.05
Above 65	4	0.72
<i>Ethnic background</i>		
White	455	81.69
Black or African America	47	8.44
American Indian or Alaska native	4	0.72
Asian	33	5.92
Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander	1	0.18
Other	17	3.05
<i>Education background</i>		
Less than high school	2	0.36
High school	33	5.92
High school graduate	104	18.67
Some college	94	16.88
2-Year degree	231	41.47
4-Year degree	83	14.9
Doctoral or professional degree	10	1.8
<i>Annual income (before tax)</i>		
Less than \$10,000	16	2.87
\$10,000–\$19,999	48	8.62
\$20,000–\$29,999	113	20.29
\$30,000–\$39,999	115	20.65
\$40,000–\$49,999	77	13.82
\$50,000–\$59,999	67	12.03
\$60,000–\$69,999	47	8.44
\$70,000–\$79,999	35	6.28
\$80,000–\$89,999	13	2.33
\$90,000–\$99,999	8	1.44
\$100,000–\$149,999	14	2.51
More than \$150,000	4	0.72
<i>Working in the current position (in years)</i>		
Lease than 3 years (≤3 years)	454	81.50
More than 3 years (>3 years)	103	18.5

Furthermore, by comparing AVEs and correlation coefficients' squares, discriminant validity of the scales was confirmed. As shown in [Table 3](#), AVE scores for all dimensions, presented in the diagonal of the matrix, exceeded the squares of paired correlation coefficients, shown in the off-diagonal of the matrix, satisfying discriminant validity ([Chin, 1998](#)).

							Can “bad” stressors spark “good” behaviors?
Factors	Items	SRW	<i>N</i> = 557 <i>t</i> -value	SMC	AVE	CR	
Intrinsic motivation (IM)	When I do work well, it gives me a feeling of accomplishment	0.831	NA	0.691	0.721	0.912	111
	I feel a great sense of personal satisfaction when I do my job well	0.865	25.245***	0.748			
	When I perform my job well it contributes to my personal growth and development	0.875	25.182***	0.766			
	My job increases my feeling of self-esteem	0.782	21.044***	0.612			
Role ambiguity (RA)	I know what my responsibilities are (R)	0.608	NA	0.369	0.692	0.870	
	I know exactly what is expected of me (R)	0.843	14.659***	0.711			
	I feel certain about how much authority I have (R)	0.725	13.545***	0.526			
Role conflict (RC)	I receive assignments without adequate resources and materials to complete them	0.543	NA	0.295	0.653	0.850	
	I work with two or more groups who operate quite differently	0.702	11.490***	0.493			
	I receive an assignment without the manpower to complete it	0.807	12.617***	0.651			
Positive emotions (PE)	I always feel relaxed at work	0.749	NA	0.561	0.669	0.910	
	I always feel happy at work	0.906	22.871***	0.821			
	I always feel satisfied at work	0.902	22.484***	0.814			
	I always feel pleasant at work	0.892	22.253***	0.795			
Negative emotions (NE)	I always feel comfortable at work	0.831	20.503***	0.690			
	I always feel upset at work	0.857	NA	0.734	0.656	0.884	
	I always feel depressed at work	0.918	28.481***	0.834			
	I always feel frustrated at work	0.815	23.775***	0.665			
External representative (ER)	I always feel boring at work	0.685	18.155***	0.469			
	I always tell outsiders this is a great place to work	0.861	NA	0.741	0.550	0.830	
	I always generate favorable goodwill for our company	0.886	28.242***	0.785			
	I always say good things about our company to others	0.922	30.409***	0.850			
Internal influence (II)	I always promote our company’s products and services	0.777	22.369***	0.603			
	I always make constructive suggestions for service improvement	0.788	NA	0.605	0.581	0.847	
	I always contribute many ideas for our product promotions and communications	0.770	18.602***	0.593			
	I always share creative solutions to customer problems with other team members	0.760	17.258***	0.577			
		0.788	17.784***	0.621			
(continued)							Table 2. Results of confirmatory factor analysis

Factors	Items	N = 557				
		SRW	t-value	SMC	AVE	CR
Service delivery (SD)	I always encourage co-workers to contribute ideas and suggestions for service improvement					
	I always follow up customer service guidelines with extreme care	0.734	NA	0.538	0.625	0.892
	I always show responsiveness to my customers.	0.865	20.109***	0.749		
	I always show my courteous and respectful to customers regardless of circumstances	0.766	17.522***	0.587		
	I always keep promises to my customers	0.787	18.421***	0.619		
	I always show personal attentiveness to my customers	0.785	18.241***	0.617		

Table 2. Notes: (R) indicates a reverse-coded item; SRW = standardized regression weights; t-values = critical ratios; NA = not available (regression coefficient is fixed to 1.0); SMC = squared multiple correlations; AVE = average variance extracted; CR = composite reliability; ***Significant at $p < 0.001$

The second-order factor analysis was applied to examine relationships between the three first-order factors and a second-order factor (boundary-spanning behaviors). Figure 2 shows the results of the second-order model with coefficients between boundary-spanning behaviors and its sub-dimensions (external representation, internal influence, and service delivery), indicating how much variances were shared among the sub-constructs. It appeared that each sub-dimension contributed differently to boundary-spanning behaviors as a holistic construct. External representation had the highest coefficient, followed by internal influence and service delivery. Overall, the second-order factor model presented a fair model fit ($\chi^2 = 1687.629$, $df = 486$, $\chi^2/df = 3.472$, $p < 0.001$, GFI = 0.835, AGFI = 0.804, NFI = 0.880, IFI = 0.912, TLI = 0.901, CFI = 0.911, RMSEA = 0.067).

4.3 Structural model

The structural path parameters were presented in Figure 3 and Table 4 with standard coefficient estimates. The model achieved an acceptable fit ($\chi^2 = 1472.527$, $df = 444$, $\chi^2/df =$

Table 3. Discriminant validity assessment

Constructs	IM	RC	RA	PE	NE	ER	II	SD
IM	0.721							
RC	0.056	0.653						
RA	0.332	0.176	0.692					
PE	0.336	0.091	0.118	0.669				
NE	0.272	0.316	0.229	0.141	0.656			
ER	0.450	0.051	0.222	0.461	0.141	0.550		
II	0.425	0.068	0.161	0.291	0.053	0.270	0.581	
SD	0.475	0.102	0.634	0.088	0.204	0.216	0.189	0.625

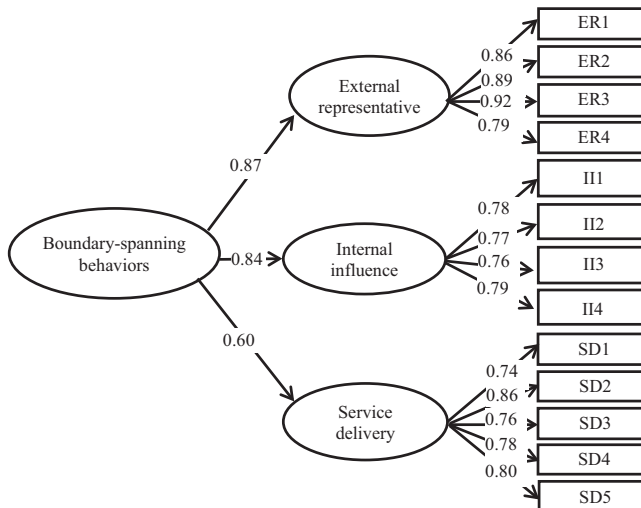


Figure 2.
Second-order factor
model of boundary-
spanning behaviors

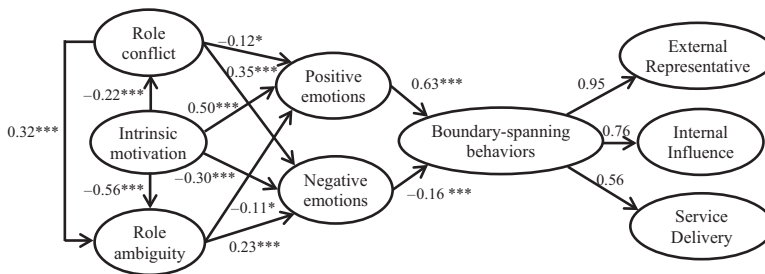


Figure 3.
Final structural
model and results of
path analysis

Hypotheses	Proposed structural model ($n = 557$)		Result
	β^a	t -Value	
$H1a: RC \rightarrow PE$	-0.12	-2.348*	Supported
$H2a: RA \rightarrow PE$	-0.11	-1.972*	Supported
$H3a: RC \rightarrow NE$	0.35	6.567***	Supported
$H4a: RA \rightarrow NE$	0.23	3.346***	Supported
$H5a: RC \rightarrow RA$	0.32	5.988***	Supported
$H6a: PE \rightarrow BSBs$	0.63	11.955***	Supported
$H7a: NE \rightarrow BSBs$	-0.16	-3.713***	Supported
$H8a: IM \rightarrow RC$	-0.22	-4.415***	Supported
$H9a: IM \rightarrow RA$	-0.56	-9.679***	Supported
$H10a: IM \rightarrow PE$	0.50	8.037***	Supported
$H11a: IM \rightarrow NE$	-0.30	-5.281***	Supported

Notes: ^aStandardized parameter estimates (β) were statistically significant ($|t\text{-values}| > 1.96$ equals to *Sig. < 0.05; $|t\text{-values}| > 2.58$ equals to **Sig. < 0.01; $|t\text{-values}| > 3.29$ equals to ***Sig. < 0.001)

Table 4.
Structural path
estimates

3.317, GFI = 0.849, AGFI = 0.820, IFI = 0.921, TLI = 0.911, CFI = 0.920, RMSEA = 0.065), in line with [Hu and Bentler \(1999\)](#) and [Byrne \(2001\)](#). All hypothesized relationships were as predicted. First, hindrance stressors had significant impacts on employees' emotions. Specifically, role conflict and role ambiguity negatively influenced positive emotions ($\beta_{RC \rightarrow PE} = -0.12, t = -2.348$; $\beta_{RA \rightarrow PE} = -0.11, t = -1.972$), accepting *H1* and *H2*. Similarly, role conflict and role ambiguity positively predicted negative emotions ($\beta_{RC \rightarrow NE} = 0.35, t = 6.567$; $\beta_{RA \rightarrow NE} = 0.23, t = 3.346$), accepting *H3* and *H4*. A significant relationship between role conflict and role ambiguity was detected ($\beta_{RC \rightarrow RA} = 0.32, t = 5.988$), so *H5* was accepted. Meanwhile, positive emotions positively led to boundary-spanning behaviors ($\beta = 0.63, t = 11.955$) and negative emotions negatively affected boundary-spanning behaviors ($\beta = -0.16, t = -3.713$), accepting *H6* and *H7*. Additionally, intrinsic motivation negatively influenced role conflict, role ambiguity and negative emotions ($\beta_{IM \rightarrow RC} = -0.22, t = -4.415$; $\beta_{IM \rightarrow RA} = -0.56, t = -9.679$; $\beta_{IM \rightarrow NE} = -0.30, t = -5.281$), while positively contributing to positive emotions ($\beta = 0.50, t = 8.037$). Therefore, *H8, H9, H10* and *H11* were accepted.

5. Discussion and conclusions

5.1 Conclusions

This study extends both the stress and the boundary-spanning literature by investigating a mechanism involving intrinsic motivation, hindrance stressors and emotions as antecedents to boundary-spanning behaviors in the hospitality industry. A closer examination of the findings yields important insights. First and foremost, role conflict and role ambiguity as hindrance stressors were shown to negatively influence frontline employees' boundary-spanning behaviors via their emotions. This substantiates transactional stress theory ([Lazarus and Folkman, 1984](#)) with evidence from the hospitality industry that role conflict or role ambiguity encountered by frontline employees decreases positive emotions while increasing negative emotions. Moreover, boundary-spanning behaviors respond to various types of emotions differently, with positive emotion exerting greater positive influence, adding to [Weiss and Cropanzano's \(1996\)](#) affective events theory, which states that workplace behaviors serve as reactions to emotional fluctuations.

Next, although hindrance stressors negatively affected customer-contact employees' positive emotions, the impact was not overwhelming, as shown in the coefficients. This points to the role of intrinsic motivation in reducing hindrance stressors and influencing subsequent emotions both directly and indirectly. These results are consistent with [Karatepe \(2015\)](#) in that employees with high levels of intrinsic motivation are likely to manage difficulties in the service encounter, regulate emotional exhaustion and meet or even exceed customer expectations.

Moreover, intrinsic motivation better contributes to frontline employees' boundary-spanning behaviors through positive emotions than through negative emotions, suggesting that high-contact employees' boundary-spanning behaviors are fostered by intrinsically motivated positive emotions. The current findings complement [Keyes \(2012\)](#), who concluded that positive emotions worked more positively and effectively than negative emotions in leading to high levels of employee functioning, and [Kuvaas et al. \(2017\)](#), who posit intrinsic motivation as a strong influence on job performance via emotional factors.

Last but not least, the coefficient between intrinsic motivation and role ambiguity is stronger than that between intrinsic motivation and role conflict, suggesting that role ambiguity is more easily regulated than role conflict. As predicted, role ambiguity can be reduced by buffering role conflict, because effective management intervention can minimize

role ambiguity, if not so much role conflict (Singh and Rhoads, 1991; Walker *et al.*, 1975). Intrinsically motivated frontline employees tend to experience low levels of hindrance stressors, indicating the effectiveness of internal drive and self-fulfillment in inspiring employees to perform beyond expectations.

5.2 Theoretical implications

This paper makes significant contributions to both stress (Abbas and Raja, 2019; Altinay *et al.*, 2019) and boundary-spanning literature (Karatepe, 2015; Yoo *et al.*, 2014) in the hospitality context. First, instead of oversimplifying the prediction that hindrance stressors only lead to bad behaviors, this study provides a more nuanced understanding of the performance-based consequences of stressors. Second, the proposed framework, linking motivation and hindrance stressors to emotions, offers a richer explanation of customer-contact boundary-spanning behaviors. Particularly, this framework advances research on frontline employee behaviors by going beyond conventional knowledge of job-related tension and negative emotions and how to mitigate such stressors (Adam, 2019; Kim *et al.*, 2019), and by advocating positive motivations and managing emotions to trigger a more proactive stance in above-and-beyond performance (Chon and Zoltan, 2019; Jiang *et al.*, 2020). Thus, this study extends and enriches the understanding of stressor-induced performance-related behavior from motivational and emotional standpoints, contributing to organizational behavior research in both general business contexts (Crawford *et al.*, 2010; Hosie *et al.*, 2019; Lu *et al.*, 2016; Naseer *et al.*, 2020; Stamper and Johlke, 2003) and hospitality settings (Kang and Jang, 2019; Min *et al.*, 2015; Yousaf *et al.*, 2020). Additionally, the present research contributes to the literature by identifying differentiated impacts of positive and negative emotions on boundary-spanning behaviors, emphasizing the importance of emotions in occupational research with new evidence (Eatough *et al.*, 2011; Kang and Jang, 2019). As a pioneering attempt, this study informs the literature with not only differential relationships stemming from role conflict and role ambiguity to boundary-spanning behaviors but also by offering the possibility of managing role ambiguity and its subsequent aftermath through role conflict.

5.3 Practical implications

The present research possesses critical practical insights for promoting boundary-spanning behaviors in hospitality organizations. First, intrinsic motivation helps foster employees' positive emotions and ease negative emotions while promoting boundary-spanning behaviors. Therefore, hospitality practitioners should cultivate such personal resources in human resource practices. Workshops, training and improved workplace design revolving around meaningful work, personal growth and competence should be arranged to promote intrinsic motivation among employees, encouraging them to become advocates of the organization's offerings. It must be noted, however, that activating intrinsic motivation, unlike extrinsic rewards, may be a challenge. Therefore, leadership should play a critical role in staffing decisions through the hiring and retention of an intrinsically motivated workforce. Building a team that demonstrates boundary-spanning behaviors can begin with the hiring process. Hospitality firms should identify and attract intrinsically motivated candidates in recruitment and selection, using approaches such as clarifying expectations up front and asking for employees' and customers' referrals. Second, organizations should guide their employees to manage emotions at work. The greater effect of positive emotion indicates its ability to induce desirable employees' behaviors, such as helping a colleague in need and/or keeping up with organizational goals. For example, roleplay training exposes employees to unexpected service encounters which may involve hindrance stressors and

require emotional processing. Third, this study serves as a reminder that hospitality organizations should aim to reduce hindrance stressors in the work environment. A well-designed organizational structure and effective management intervention would be helpful to this end. Explicit job descriptions, effective supervisor–subordinate communication and employee feedback loops are all valid for helping buffer high-contact employees’ role-related stress.

5.4 Limitations and future research directions

This study is not free from limitations and therefore provides avenues for future research. First, the job-related stress facing frontline employees is not limited to role conflict and role ambiguity. Further research can incorporate other stressors, such as role overload, work–life conflict and prolonged work hours, as well as the dual impact of challenge stressors and hindrance stressors, into the framework for future exploration.

Second, outside the scope of this study, future research can explore the mediating effects within the mechanism, as well as the possible moderating effects of personality traits (extraversion, introversion, etc.). Relatedly, more personal resources (e.g. self-efficacy, psychological capital, political skills) could be introduced to help explain frontline employees’ stress relief and boundary-spanning behaviors.

Third, diversity in workforce environments may be another factor that possibly influences employee motivation and behavior. Because this current study was conducted in the USA, respondents’ understanding of boundary-spanning behaviors may be attributable to their respective cultural backgrounds. Therefore, future studies are encouraged to validate the framework across not only different types of hospitality businesses (e.g. budget, mid-market and up-market) but also the cultural backgrounds of employees.

Fourth, the use of self-reported measures potentially raises concerns about common method bias, despite strategies adopted in this study to minimize such threats. In this study, respondents were informed of the anonymity of their responses and the absence of a right or wrong answer to a question, which helped reduce social desirability bias. Also, the measurements of scale were adapted from different previous empirical studies in the hospitality context, with unclear and ambiguous expressions eradicated. Furthermore, to reduce respondents’ estimation of the relationships, measurements of the predictor and criterion variables were not placed in sequential orders (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2012). Although M-Turk is considered an effective and valid data collection platform, caution still should be exercised when interpreting the generalizability of the findings. It is necessary to cross-validate the findings with actual behaviors observed at work. More organic research designs such as field experiments are encouraged to better understand the dynamics. Another logical next step would be to diversify the respondent pool and test the robustness of the study results across different samples. Additionally, the scales used in the mechanism should be refined in future endeavors. To this end, interviews with frontline employees to develop items accounting for job-specific characteristics would be ideal.

In conclusion, academicians and practitioners should grasp the impact of such stressors on employee performance. To the knowledge of the authors, however, no study has examined how hindrance stressors, considered “bad” stressors, affect boundary-spanning behaviors, accounting for the roles of workers’ motivation and emotion. Rather than suggesting that hindrance stressors are relevant only to counterproductive behaviors, this study extends both the stress and the boundary-spanning literature by revealing the impact of hindrance stressors on frontline employees’ boundary-spanning behaviors. The results demonstrated that hindrance stressors exhibited a negative indirect impact on high-contact employees’ boundary-spanning behaviors through emotions. Intrinsic motivation, however,

worked as an effective individual resource to reduce hindrance stressors and influence subsequent emotions in favor of boundary-spanning behaviors. This information enables hospitality firms to alleviate and manage employees’ work stress for favorable business outcomes.

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